SCREEN, PREVENT, TRANSPLANT

THE ESSENCE OF LIVER DISEASE DETECTION AND SELECTION

Liver diseases are a significant health problem, and they are being increasingly identified in patients today due to the rising incidence and higher awareness. Liver diseases have a varied spectrum, ranging from fatty liver disease to inflammation in the liver to liver fibrosis and liver cirrhosis. Also, some conditions affect the liver suddenly, causing acute liver problems and failure.

Chronic liver diseases, which finally progress to their advanced stage known as cirrhosis, are primarily caused by Hepatitis (Hep B or Hep C), Metabolic dysfunction associated steatotic Liver disease (MASLD) (previously known as non-alcoholic fatty liver disease or NAFLD) and excessive Alcohol intake.

Hepatitis (hep B and C) are a result of blood-borne viral infections that slowly damage the liver over the years, resulting in progressive fibrosis, which ultimately leads to cirrhosis. As the liver functions deteriorate, the patients clinically start to get decompensation.

Alcohol intake has devastating effects not just on the liver but also on the entire human body. Currently, more than 30 per cent of liver cirrhosis is due to alcohol consumption. Alcohol affects the liver in a more profound manner, such that it can damage the liver suddenly, causing acute liver problems, and slowly affect it, leading to fibrosis and cirrhosis over the years. Women are more prone to liver damage from drinking alcohol than men.

MASLD - Rapidly changing lifestyles have led to a high incidence of liver disease. Sedentary lifestyle, diabetes, high cholesterol, and obesity predispose to fatty liver disease, which is becoming a growing health concern. Studies estimate that almost one in three adults has fatty liver, and around 20% of patients with fatty liver eventually develop cirrhosis if proper treatment and care are not taken.

Acute Liver Failure is the sudden deterioration of liver functions leading to liver failure in an otherwise normal liver. These are mainly caused by hepatitis A or E, toxins like paracetamol or certain drugs, and a variety of other causes.

Acute on chronic liver diseases (ACLD) are conditions where liver function suddenly worsens on a chronic liver disease. these could happen because of superimposed hepatitis, alcohol abuse or intake of certain hepatotoxic drugs.

Liver diseases in children are different from those in adults. The common symptoms of liver disease in children are jaundice, clay coloured stools, black tarry stools, growth failure, poor appetite, weight loss, and swelling of the abdomen.

The most common cause of chronic liver disease in newborns/small babies is biliary atresia. Children could also suffer from metabolic or genetic liver disease, Chronic hepatitis B, hepatitis C and autoimmune liver disease.

Fatty liver disease is a rapidly increasing problem in children nowadays due to their diet and lifestyle, and this could lead to cirrhosis in young adults.

Liver cancer, which can develop in either chronic liver disease or in a normal liver, has a rising incidence in India. Now there are more than 100,000 new liver cancer cases annually, resulting in more than 50,000 deaths.

Liver transplantation is a complex procedure that requires multidisciplinary care and a large, dedicated team that works in coordination to achieve a 90% success rate in patients. Diseases that require transplant are mainly Chronic Liver Disease (CLD) that have decompensated or conditions leading to Acute Liver failure (ALF).





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The decompensation in cirrhosis happens after prolonged or severe illness. It may manifest in the form of jaundice, ascites, encephalopathy, kidney dysfunction, etc. In such patients, a Liver transplant is needed as the definitive treatment.

Emergency or early Liver transplant is a life-saving treatment in patients with Acute liver failure.

Primary liver tumours (originating from liver cells, also known as hepatocellular carcinoma or cholangiocarcinoma) and secondary tumours of the liver (liver metastases or spread from other cancers, such as colon cancer) can be treated by liver surgery or transplantation if detected early.

Liver transplantation is essentially of two types, based on the kind of liver donor.

DDLT - Deceased donor liver transplantation or cadaveric transplants where the liver is procured from an eligible brain-dead donor.

LDLT - where the liver donor is a living related donor who donates a part of the liver based on extensive evaluations, and this becomes possible because of the unique property of regeneration, which is inherent in the liver.

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